

Singapore Banks

1Q25 preview: A steady quarter but watch for potential guidance changes

1Q profitability to remain strong supported by seasonality...

Singapore banks will be providing their 1Q25 trading updates starting with UOB on May 7th, followed by DBS (May 8th) and OCBC (May 9th). For 1Q, we expect earnings to remain decent with ROEs sustaining at 14.0% on average, with sequential improvement from last quarter, mainly due to seasonally **higher fee income** and **lower opex** qoq, together with solid **other non-interest income** and **flattish credit costs**, to help offset a **gradual decline in NIMs in 1Q**.

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Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.**...while all focus is on potential guidance changes amid macro uncertainties**

Given the heightened uncertainties surrounding tariffs and their impact on the macro outlook as well as heightening market expectations for Fed rate cuts, we believe the focus of the upcoming earnings season will be on guidance updates and banks' near term strategies especially with respect to: **(1)** NIMs, with SG banks only incorporating 1-3 Fed rate cuts in their 2025 guidance (1/2/3 cuts baked in by UOB/DBS/OCBC), less than current FFR market pricing of 4 cuts, and potentially 8 cuts in the GSe recession scenario (we have baked in 5 rate cuts for this year - GSe probability-weighted FED forecast); **(2)** Credit cost/ asset quality — we do not expect significant deterioration in balance sheets for now, with our covered banks noting that trade loans contribute mid-single digit to 10% of the total portfolio and direct exposure to US exporters should be smaller, and thus expecting a limited first order impact from tariffs. That said, we highlight concerns around second order impacts and whether this new environment could see banks adding more to their provision management overlay (GSe of 20-28bps CoC for 2025); and **(3)** Loan growth and conservatism on underwriting (GSe of 2-4% yoy growth in 2025). Additionally, we focus on any UOB management commentary on its ROE target of 14% by 2026E, and how the bank can pivot its strategy in this environment.

Remain positive on Singapore banks; Buy DBS, UOB, OCBC

SG banks' share prices are down -12% MTD and -7% YTD, underperforming the STI (-8%/-4%) amid expectations for an accelerated and increasing Fed cut cycle and uncertainties around US tariffs. We believe current share prices are reflective of Fed forward futures. In this highly fluid environment, we continue to favor stocks with

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robust and sustainable profitability and the capability to increase capital returns, and thus we remain Buy on all three SG banks.

1Q25 Preview: Decent quarter but NIMs to see pressure

Singapore banks will be providing their 1Q25 trading updates starting with UOB on May 7th, followed by DBS (May 8th) and OCBC (May 9th). For 1Q, we expect earnings to remain decent with ROEs sustaining at 14.0% on average, with sequential improvement from last quarter and EPS higher at +8% qoq, mainly due to: 1) **Higher qoq fee income** mainly from wealth due to normal seasonally higher investment activities in 1Q; 2) **Higher other non-interest income** as we expect investment gains to be similar to 4Q24 and insurance profit of OCBC to return to a normalized level; 3) **Seasonally lower opex**; 4) **flattish credit costs**, for which we have baked in some buffer for macro uncertainties; partly offset by 5) **Gradual decline in NIMs in 1Q**, reflecting FED cuts towards the end of 2024 together with the sharp decline in SORA. We expect OCBC to see the largest qoq core net income increase of +9% qoq with UOB the smallest at -1% qoq.

- **DBS:** We forecast 1Q25 net profit of S\$2,828mn (+8% qoq/-4% yoy), with steady performance across operating lines except a decline in margins, and ROE elevated at 16.9%, driven by seasonality. We anticipate +23% qoq fee income growth on the back of usual higher activity levels in 1Q and lower opex at -5% qoq, as well as +1.8% growth in loans, partly offset by a 4bps qoq decline in NIM, as we factor in higher than expected pass-through of Fed rate cuts into the 3-month-compounded SORA in 1Q25. Despite heightened macro uncertainties, we expect asset quality to remain stable and bake in some buffer with a credit cost forecast of 20bps, at the higher end of guidance range of 17-20bps.
- **OCBC:** We forecast 1Q25 net profit of S\$1,834mn (+9% qoq/-8% yoy). Similar to DBS, we expect sequential improvement from the previous quarter across operating lines due to seasonality, except for margins. We expect NIM to decline 5bps qoq given higher than expected pass-through of Fed cuts to SORA. We anticipate non-NII to be higher qoq on higher fees due to seasonally higher activity levels in the wealth business as well as higher other non-NII as we expect profit from the insurance business to return to normalized levels. We forecast credit costs at 24bps, higher than 22bps in 2024 as we bake in some buffer for the macro uncertainties, but still in-line with the company's guidance of 20-25bps.
- **UOB:** We forecast 1Q net profit of S\$1,504mn (-1.2% qoq/+0.1% yoy), mainly because we expect the tax rate to return to a normalized level. For PBT we expect a sequential improvement similar to the other 2 SG banks +7.8% qoq, -0.4% yoy, with seasonal improvement in fee income and opex to more than offset lower NII. Similar to peers, we expect UOB to see a 4bp margin decline qoq in 1Q. For credit costs, we expect 1Q25 to come in at 27bps, similar to 28bps in 4Q24 and inline with guidance of 25-30bps, as we conservatively bake in some buffer for the macro uncertainties.

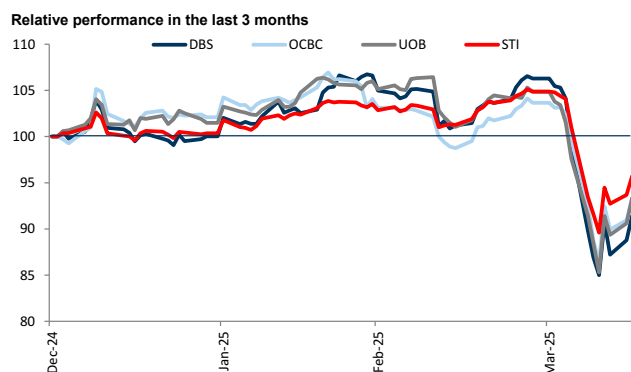
Exhibit 1: Singapore banks' results preview

\$mm	DBS					OCBC					UOB				
	1Q25E	4Q24	QoQ (%)	1Q24	YoY (%)	1Q25E	4Q24	QoQ (%)	1Q24	YoY (%)	1Q25E	4Q24	QoQ (%)	1Q24	YoY (%)
NII	3,725	3,728	(0.1)	3,505	6.3	2,461	2,455	0.2	2,437	1.0	2,410	2,452	(1.7)	2,362	2.1
Fee Income	1,192	968	23.2	1,043	14.3	532	517	2.8	479	11.0	650	567	14.6	580	12.0
Other Non-NII	850	809	5.1	1,009	(15.8)	608	444	37.0	710	(14.3)	456	442	3.2	581	(21.5)
Non- NII	2,042	1,777	14.9	2,052	(0.5)	1,140	961	18.6	1,189	(4.1)	1,106	1,009	9.6	1,161	(4.8)
Operating Expenses	(2,266)	(2,395)	(5.4)	(2,079)	9.0	(1,454)	(1,560)	(6.8)	(1,346)	8.0	(1,475)	(1,559)	(5.4)	(1,475)	0.0
PPOP	3,501	3,110	12.6	3,478	0.7	2,147	1,856	15.7	2,280	(5.8)	2,041	1,902	7.3	2,048	(0.3)
Impairment charges	(219)	(209)	4.7	(135)	62.1	(192)	(208)	(7.6)	(169)	13.7	(238)	(227)	4.7	(163)	45.9
Pre-tax Profit	3,347	2,960	13.1	3,394	(1.4)	2,202	1,887	16.7	2,343	(6.0)	1,817	1,685	7.8	1,825	(0.4)
Net Profit	2,828	2,523	12.1	2,951	(4.2)	1,834	1,687	8.7	1,982	(7.5)	1,504	1,522	(1.2)	1,502	0.1
Core Net Profit	2,828	2,623	7.8	2,951	(4.2)	1,834	1,687	8.7	1,982	(7.5)	1,520	1,539	(1.2)	1,565	(2.9)
Reported NIM (%)	2.11	2.15	-4bp	2.14	-3bp	2.10	2.15	-5bp	2.27	-17bp	1.96	2.00	-4bp	2.02	-6bp
Credit Costs (bps)	20	19	1bp	13	7bp	24	27	-3bp	23	1bp	28	27	1bp	20	8bp
Cost-to-income Ratio	39	44	-4pp	37	2pp	40	46	-5pp	37	3pp	42	45	-3pp	42	0pp
Gross Loans	438,815	436,684	0.5	431,000	1.8	321,271	319,166	0.7	301,000	6.7	341,292	338,000	1.0	322,634	5.8
ROA (%)	1.36	1.30	7bp	1.55	-19bp	1.17	1.10	7bp	1.35	-18bp	1.12	1.10	1bp	1.20	-8bp
ROE (%)	16.9	16.0	92bp	19.5	-262bp	12.5	11.9	65bp	14.7	-214bp	12.7	12.8	-18bp	14.1	-145bp

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

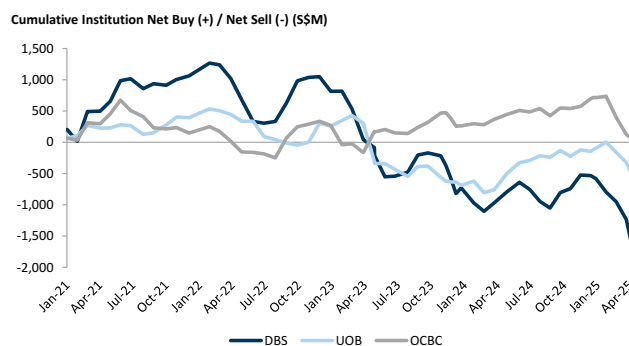
1Q25 in six charts

Exhibit 2: All three banks' share prices fell sharply after the US tariff announcement



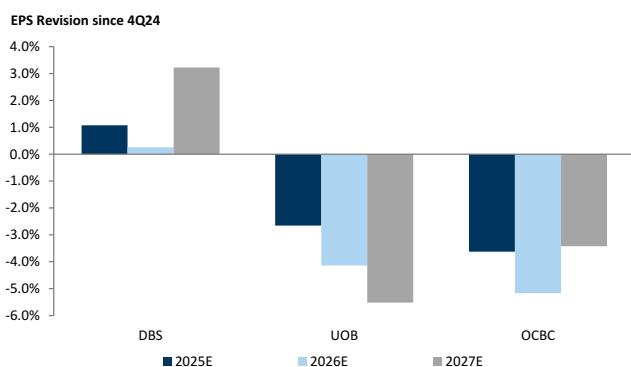
Source: Thomson Reuters, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: All 3 banks saw outflows from institutional investors in 1Q25



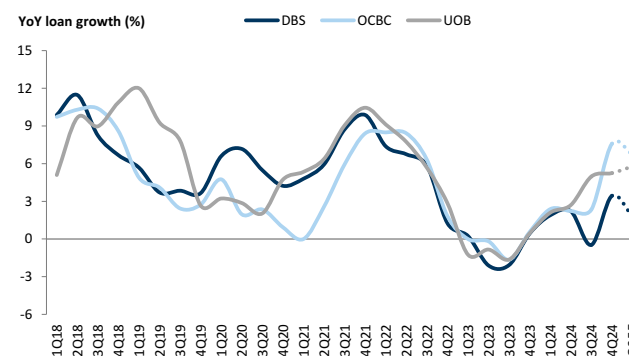
Source: SGX, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Consensus EPS have been revised down for UOB and OCBC, while flattish for DBS

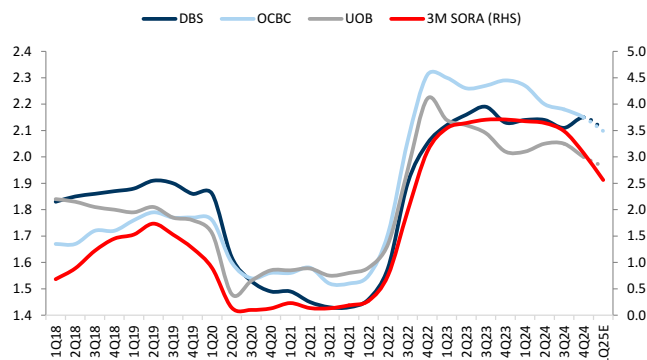


Source: Bloomberg

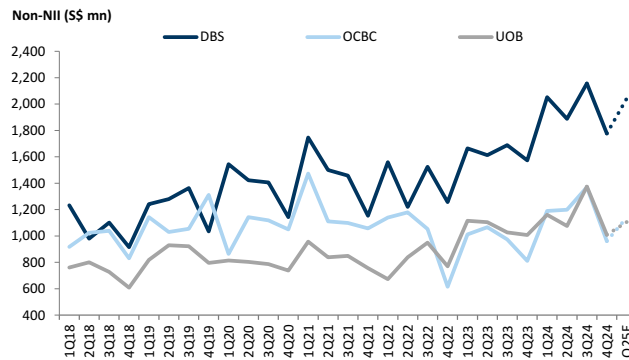
Exhibit 5: We anticipate credit growth to remain at mid to low single-digit levels for the Singapore banks in 1Q25, with OCBC showing the highest growth



Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

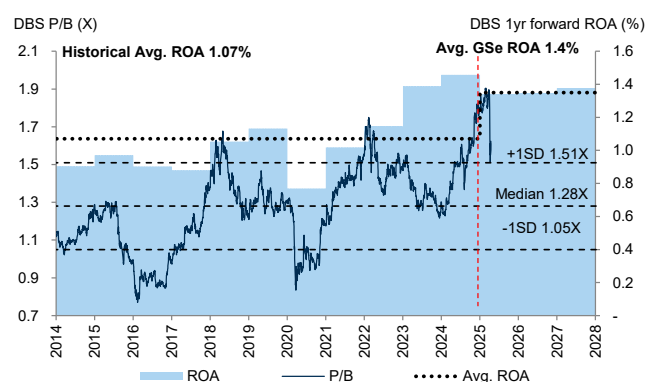
Exhibit 6: NIMs to trend lower in 1Q25 given the declining SORA

Source: MAS, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

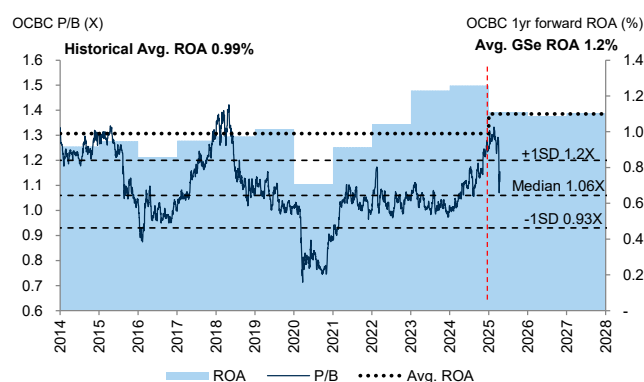
Exhibit 7: We estimate non-NII to improve qoq given seasonality

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

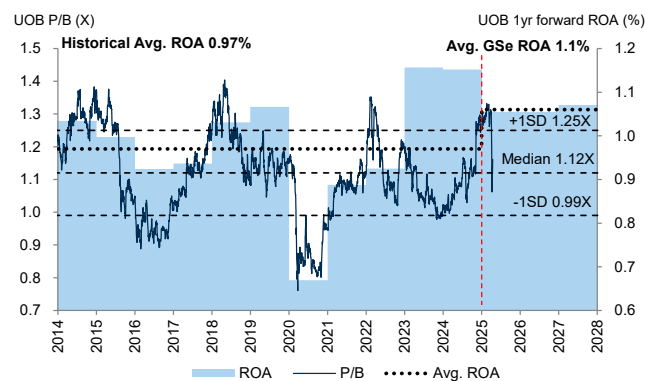
Valuation

Exhibit 8: DBS is still trading at more than 1 std dev above its historical 10-year P/B median...

Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: ...while OCBC is trading close to its historical 10-year P/B median...

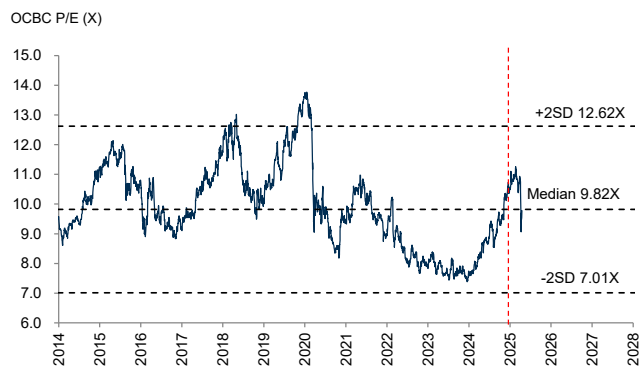
Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: ...and so is UOB

Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 11: On a P/E basis, DBS is trading between its historical 10-year median and 1 St.Dev below...

Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 12: ...as is OCBC...**Exhibit 13: ...as well as UOB**

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Oversea-Chinese Banking Corp.

We are Buy rated on OCBC with a 12-month target price of S\$18.3 (based on a two-stage DDM). Key risks include: (-) Sudden or sharper-than-expected Fed cut cycle; (-) Changes in strategy to return capital; (-) Unexpected dilutive M&A activity.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - United Overseas Bank

We are Buy rated on UOB with a 12-month target price of S\$41.9 (based on two-stage DDM). Key risks include: (-) Unexpected acceleration or deeper Fed rate cuts; (-) Poor execution of growth strategy in Citi franchise; (-) Unexpected deterioration in asset quality.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - DBS Group

We are Buy-rated on DBS with a 12-month target price of S\$49.8 (based on two-stage DDM). Key downside risks: (-) Unexpected acceleration in rate cuts; (-) Unexpected asset quality deterioration; (-) Mismanaged top management transition.

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Reg AC

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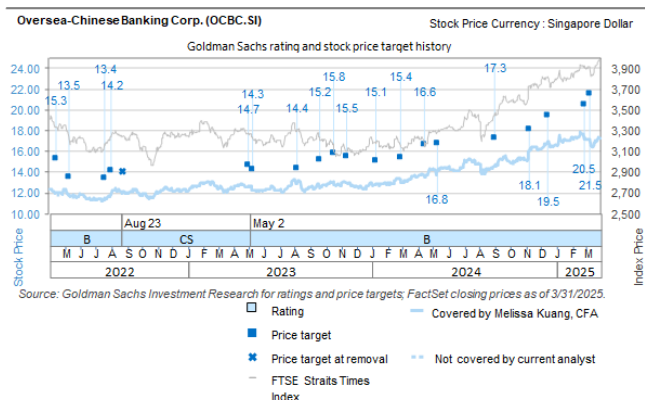
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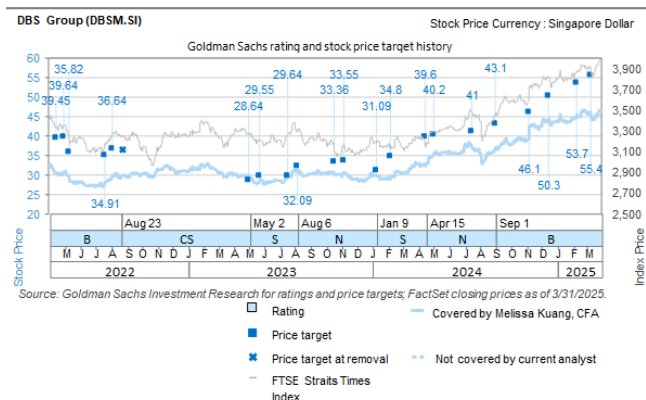
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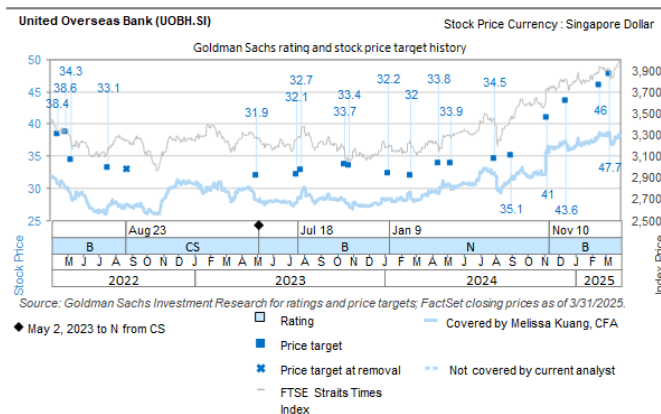
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